

Canon

Canons are similar to rounds, but the voices that enter the canon following, or imitating, the lead voice may differ in rhythm or pitch. While these variations allow for more creativity, the various presentations of the canon theme are still closely tied to the original statement.

▽ Pachelbel's Canon

Composed c.1694, but unpublished until 1919, Johann Pachelbel's *Canon in D* is the most famous canon ever written. It is scored for three violins and a bass instrument, which repeats the same eight-note motif, or ground bass, 28 times.

Voice 1

Voice 2

Voice 3

Voice 4

Voice 2 repeats voice 1 from two measures earlier.

Voice 3 repeats the material from voice 2.

Fugue

Just like a canon, a fugue theme (subject) is introduced and then imitated by two or more voices. Each entrance of the subject starts on a different pitch. After each voice performs the theme once, the exposition of the piece is over. Then, "episodes" or "development" sections appear, which employ strict contrapuntal compositional techniques.

▽ Fuga I, Bach's *The Well-Tempered Clavier*

This keyboard fugue written in 1722 (BWV 846) is a textbook example of fugal counterpoint. The 14-note subject appears 24 times, evenly spread among the four voices.

Fugue theme, in the alto voice.

2

Imitation of the theme a fifth higher, in the soprano voice.

1

3

Theme appears in the tenor, down a fourth.

4

Last appearance of the theme, in the bass, down an octave.